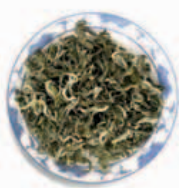


## CHENGDU CHINA

# A Cultural Brew in Chengdu

It's a summer day in Chengdu, the humid capital of Sichuan province, and people are languishing at a riverside teahouse, paralyzed by the heat despite shade from overhanging ginkgo and willow trees. In front of each is a thermos of hot water and a steaming cup of tea – which, according to Chinese medicine, is in fact “cooling,” making it the perfect thing to drink in this climate.



Chengdu, the capital of Sichuan province, is a modern, overcrowded metropolis – but patches of traditional culture survive among the expressways and offices, and especially in the people. The city dates

back to prehistory, and became known as a base for rebel armies around AD 200, before blossoming as a trading nexus on the “tea-horse roads,” which spread out from central China into distant Tibet by the 16th century. Tea has been drunk in China for millennia; there are hundreds of varieties of tea and as many ways of serving it. But teahouse culture – with teahouses serving as hubs of local communities, like a bar or pub in the West – really only survives nowadays in Sichuan, and most obviously in Chengdu.

Sichuanese teahouses take many forms, from a few chairs in the corner of a temple park to grand, antique-style buildings with heavy wooden furniture and a theater stage for watching Sichuanese opera. Take a seat in either and a waiter will materialize to offer you tea; sometimes there's not much choice – just

jasmine or green tea – but other times you may be offered a three-page menu of regional specialties. Tea is normally served in a *gaiwan cha* – a squat, lidded cup and saucer, which is used as a teapot elsewhere in China for pouring the brew into thimble-sized cups, but here it's drunk from directly. Locals pick up the whole assemblage in one hand to take a sip, carefully holding the lid only slightly open to keep back floating leaves. Demanding far less skill, *zhuye qing*, a green tea from the forested foothills of holy Mount Emei, always arrives in a glass tumbler so that you can watch the tiny, spear-shaped buds rise and fall as the drink cools.

The waiter will leave behind a flask of hot water, or periodically return with a metal kettle. Some establishments serve Sichuanese snacks, or at least a plate of dried beans or melon seeds so you can munch on something as you watch your fellow drinkers chat idly in the Sichuanese dialect, or play cards or mah jong. If the teahouse is a theater, don't expect the audience to devote too much attention to the play; they'll know the story already, and catching up with friends or swapping stories is far more important.

## Sichuanese Snacks

Sichuan is famous for the variety of its snacks, or **xiaochi**, which, unlike many Sichuanese main courses, are not always searingly spicy. Savory “**carriypole noodles**” (*dandan mian*) are named after the way street hawkers of this dish used to cart their wares around, while gruesome-sounding “**husband-wife lung slices**” (*fuqi feipian*) feature slivers of beef in a mild soy/vinegar/chili-pepper dressing. Both *chao shou* (Sichuanese ravioli in plain soup) and *tangyuan* (rice flour dumplings stuffed with sweet sesame paste) are pepper-free, though bland *douhua*, **soft tofu**, comes with hot relish on the side. Upping the heat considerably, *gege* (rice-coated **spare ribs** cooked in tiny steamers), *liang fen* (**cold bean noodles** in a chili pepper/vinegar sauce), and *ranmian* (the aptly-named “**incandescent noodles**”) are best avoided unless you have an asbestos mouth.



Above Tea-drinkers watch Sichuan opera at Wuhou Temple in Chengdu



## The Best Teahouses in Sichuan Province

### Heming Teahouse inexpensive

Everyone in Chengdu knows Heming Teahouse. Set underneath a wisteria vine just inside the city's most central park, this open-air teahouse looks out across a large ornamental pond. There's a large bronze kettle at the entrance (actually a water spout for you to wash your hands on the way in), the regulation bamboo chairs, and some solid, inconveniently shaped stone tables. Cruising hairdressers, shoulder masseurs, and even earwax removers move among the locals, some of whom seem to spend the entire day here. There's just the right blend of indifference and attention shown to you by the staff. Weekend crowds sprawl, chew sunflower seeds, and slurp their drinks cheerfully, as they gossip, browse their newspapers, or stare vacantly at youngsters bumping around in boats on the pond.

A cafeteria off to one side sells hot and cold snacks, and once a year there's a food fair in the park, where you can buy other local treats such as “three gunshots” – three sticky-rice balls that are bounced off a drum into a tray of toasted flour and served in dark caramel; more performance art than a meal.

**North Gate, Renmin Park, Chengdu; open 6 AM–7 PM daily**

### Also in Eastern Sichuan

For a rural riverside setting, leave Chengdu and head to the village of **Huanglong Xi**, whose rickety antique streets and low-key temples have made it something of a tourist phenomenon. For a similar experience with less raucous crowds, try **Pingle**, about 55 miles (90 km) west of Chengdu. There are wonderfully atmospheric teahouses in **Zigong**, a former industrial town a day's journey from Chengdu; here you can relax over tea in the flagstoned courtyards of Wangye Miao and Huanhou Gong, two splendidly ornate merchants' guildhalls commemorating the town's salt-mining heyday.

### Also in Western Sichuan

For a totally different take on what makes a good cup of tea in Sichuan, head to western Sichuan. The teahouses scattered through dusty backlanes in **Songpan** – a Qing dynasty garrison town encircled by stone walls and snowy mountains – make great perches for watching the Muslim, Tibetan, and Qiang population go about their business. In the remote monastery towns of **Litang** and **Langmusi**, pluck up the courage to try Tibetan butter tea: a rare mix of tea, yak butter, salt, and water churned into a soup.